

Walmart (Testing): Accelerating Progress Towards Zero Food Waste

Walmart (Testing) has set ambitious goals for waste reduction, positioning itself as a potential leader in minimizing food waste across its operations. With a target of zero waste to landfill in U.S. operations by 2025, and a parallel goal of sending zero food waste to landfill, the company is demonstrating a clear commitment. ReFED believes that by leveraging its existing initiatives and exploring new opportunities, Walmart (Testing) can significantly accelerate its progress and generate substantial environmental and economic benefits.

From Commitment to Action: Project Gigaton and Beyond

Walmart (Testing)'s commitment extends beyond its direct operations through its ambitious Project Gigaton. This initiative aims to reduce 1 billion metric tons of GHG emissions from its global value chain by 2030, recognizing the significant impact of supply chain activities on overall environmental footprint. This commitment provides a strong framework for addressing food waste throughout the supply chain, from farm to shelf.

Leveraging AI for Inventory Optimization

Walmart (Testing) is already implementing AI-powered inventory management systems to optimize ordering and reduce spoilage. This proactive approach demonstrates a willingness to invest in innovative solutions to minimize waste at the source. Further refinement and expansion of these systems could yield significant reductions in unsold inventory and associated food waste.

Expanding "Ugly Produce" Programs

The company's pilot "ugly produce" programs in select stores offer a valuable opportunity to address consumer perceptions of imperfect produce. By marketing these items at a reduced price, Walmart (Testing) can tap into a growing consumer demand for sustainable options and reduce the amount of perfectly edible food that is discarded due to cosmetic imperfections. Scaling these programs across more stores and product categories could have a substantial impact.

Strengthening Food Rescue and Donation Efforts

Walmart (Testing) has a long-standing food donation program, partnering with Feeding America and local food banks through its "fresh food donation program." This existing infrastructure provides a solid foundation for further expanding food rescue efforts. Optimizing logistics and ensuring efficient distribution of surplus food can maximize the impact of these donations, providing valuable resources to communities in need.

Addressing Methane Emissions: A Critical Opportunity

Walmart (Testing) is taking steps to reduce methane emissions through investments in anaerobic digesters and exploration of refrigerants with lower global warming potential. These efforts are crucial, as methane is a potent greenhouse gas with a significant impact on climate change.

Collaborating with Suppliers on Agricultural Practices

The company's collaboration with suppliers to reduce methane emissions from agricultural practices, particularly in beef and dairy supply chains, is particularly noteworthy. This engagement demonstrates a commitment to addressing the root causes of food waste and environmental impact throughout the entire value chain. ReFED's Insights Engine can help identify specific interventions and best practices for reducing agricultural waste and associated methane emissions.

Next Steps: A Roadmap for Collaboration

To further accelerate its progress towards zero food waste, ReFED recommends the following next steps for Walmart (Testing):

- **Quantify the Impact:** Conduct a comprehensive food waste assessment to quantify the current volume and sources of food waste across its operations and supply chain. This data will provide a baseline for measuring progress and identifying key areas for improvement.
- **Expand Data-Driven Solutions:** Leverage ReFED's Insights Engine to identify and prioritize the most cost-effective and impactful food waste reduction solutions for Walmart (Testing)'s specific context.
- **Deepen Supplier Engagement:** Collaborate with key suppliers to implement best practices for preventing food waste at the source, including improved harvesting techniques, optimized packaging, and enhanced cold chain management.
- **Invest in Innovative Technologies:** Explore and pilot emerging technologies for food waste reduction, such as advanced sorting systems, predictive analytics, and innovative packaging solutions.
- **Publicly Report Progress:** Regularly report on progress towards its food waste reduction goals, demonstrating transparency and accountability to stakeholders.

By taking these steps, Walmart (Testing) can solidify its position as a leader in food waste reduction and generate significant environmental, social, and economic benefits. ReFED is eager to partner with Walmart (Testing) and Jane Smith, Senior Sustainability Manager, to achieve these ambitious goals.